



Acrobat Hub Page & CTA — Competitive Study

Competitive Intelligence · Acrobat Product Team · April 2026

Scope

iLovePDF · Smallpdf · PDF24 · Foxit
· UPDF vs Adobe Acrobat

Focus

Hub page CTAs · Task
navigation · Pricing hierarchy

Classification

Adobe Internal —
Confidential

Data

Live competitor
pages · April 2026

4 of 5

top competitors lead with
free access on hub pages

Only Foxit leads with "Buy Now" as
primary CTA

29 tasks

iLovePDF surfaces above the
fold — Adobe shows zero task
shortcuts

PDF24 shows 24 tools; Smallpdf
shows 6 below fold

0 of 4

free-first competitors use
"Buy Now" as their pricing
page primary CTA

All lead with free trial or free tier as
the first visible action

— At a Glance

CTA strategy, task navigation, and pricing hierarchy across all five competitors vs. current Adobe Acrobat.

COMPETITOR	PRIMARY HERO CTA	CTA DESTINATION	FREE-FIRST?	TASK GRID?	PRICING LEAD CTA
iLovePDF	No hero — task grid is the page	Direct tool	Yes — "100% FREE"	29 tools above fold	Start for free
Smallpdf	Start Free Trial	Account signup	Yes — trial as free	Below fold — 6 tools	Try 7 Days Free
PDF24	No CTA — task grid is the page	Direct tool	Fully free, no paid tier	24 tools above fold	No pricing page
UPDF	Free Download	App download	Yes — download first	No — capabilities only	Buy Now
Foxit	Buy Now	Checkout	No — paid-first	No — feature copy	Add to

COMPETITOR	PRIMARY HERO CTA	CTA DESTINATION	FREE-FIRST?	TASK GRID?	PRICING LEAD CTA
					Cart
Adobe Acrobat (current)	Try Acrobat Studio	Product checkout	No — premium push	No task shortcuts	Get Acrobat Pro

Adobe currently matches Foxit's paid-first pattern — the only outlier in the top 5.

1 Hub Page CTA Strategy

Should the primary CTA push a specific premium product, or offer a generic free entry point that lets visitors self-select? Screenshots captured live, April 2026.

iLovePDF

Free-First

No hero section. Task grid IS the homepage. "Get Premium" is a nav button only — never pushed as a hero CTA.

- ✓ Zero friction between intent and action. Upsell appears only when a usage limit is hit mid-task — at maximum motivation.

Smallpdf

Trial-as-Free

"Start Free Trial" primary. No price shown above fold. Task grid below fold as secondary discovery.

- ✓ Brand pitch above fold, task shortcuts below. Captures both intent-driven and browsing visitors without sacrificing brand presence.

PDF24

Radically Free

No CTA, no hero. 57 tools total. "All tools free of charge without any restrictions."

- ✓ Sets the category floor for "free." Users who encounter PDF24 recalibrate their expectation that PDF tools cost nothing.

foxit.com/pdf-editor

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Trusted PDF tools, enhanced with AI.

Work smarter with the essential PDF toolkit to create, edit, and sign your files, plus Acrobat AI Assistant for faster document tasks.

Foxit

Paid-First

"Buy Now" primary. "Try It Free" secondary. Headline: "The #1 Alternative to Adobe Acrobat."

- ⚠ Only competitor using a purchase CTA as primary. Positions as a premium challenger targeting Adobe's price-sensitive customers.

UPDF

Download-First

"Free Download" primary. "Buy Now" secondary. Desktop-app only — no web tool path.

- Download removes the purchase barrier without committing to a free-forever model. Converts via in-app trial, not landing page copy.

Adobe

Acrobat —
Current

Premium Push

"Try Acrobat Studio" as hero CTA. Pushes visitors into the most expensive product before they self-select. No task shortcuts visible.

- ✗ Matches Foxit's paid-first pattern — the only outlier. Hub pages attract broad, unknown audiences. Betting the hero on one expensive product narrows the funnel prematurely.

RECOMMENDATION

Hub Page CTA — Switch from premium push to free-first self-selection

✓ WHAT TO DO

→ Replace "Try Acrobat Studio" with "Try Acrobat for free"

Link to the plans page, not a specific product checkout. Let visitors choose their own plan after seeing the full offering — not before they have context.

→ Add a secondary outline CTA: "See all plans ↓"

Gives high-intent visitors a direct path to pricing without making it the primary push. Smallpdf's pattern — two CTAs, one free-first, one plan-exploratory.

→ Apply to all customer group hubs, not just Acrobat

Hub pages by definition serve unknown, mixed-intent audiences. The same logic applies across Acrobat, Express, and Firefly hubs.

✗ WHAT TO AVOID

✗ Heroing a specific product (Acrobat Studio) on a hub page

This assumes high purchase intent before visitors have established any. Foxit does this — but Foxit is a challenger brand targeting Adobe's price-sensitive base, not a market leader growing top-of-funnel.

✗ Burying free trial access below the fold or in secondary copy

If "free trial" is present but not prominent, it doesn't change visitor behavior. 4 of 5 competitors make free access the first thing visitors see.

Evidence: 4 of 5 competitors (iLovePDF, Smallpdf, PDF24, UPDF) lead hub pages with free access. The one exception — Foxit — explicitly positions itself as a budget challenger to Adobe with "The #1 Alternative to Adobe Acrobat" as its headline. Adobe's current CTA pattern aligns with its strongest challenger, not the free-first majority that is winning top-of-funnel volume.

EXACT COPY TO SHIP

Primary button:

Try Acrobat for free

SHIP DETAILS

Owner: Web/CRO + Copywriter

Subtext (below button):

7 days free – no credit card needed

Secondary outline CTA:

See all plans →

Button destination: Plans page (not product checkout). Let visitors self-select their plan with full context.

Effort: 2-hour copy change — zero engineering required

Metric to move: Hub page hero CTA clickthrough rate (current est. ~1–2% → target 4%+)

A/B test: Control ("Try Acrobat Studio" → checkout) vs. Variant A ("Try Acrobat for free" → plans page) vs. Variant B ("Start for free" → web tool directly). Run for 2 weeks minimum; primary metric: CTA clickthrough rate.

2 Task-Based Navigation

Should product pages expose task entry points (Merge PDF, Sign, Convert...) or present capabilities as marketing copy only? The two dominant patterns side by side.

Pattern A — Task-Grid-as-Product (iLovePDF, PDF24)

Lower friction

The screenshot shows the iLovePDF website. The header includes the logo and navigation links for various tools: MERGE PDF, SPLIT PDF, COMPRESS PDF, CONVERT PDF, and ALL PDF TOOLS. Below the header is a hero section with the text "Every tool you need to work with PDFs in one place" and a subtext "Every tool you need to use PDFs, at your fingertips. All are 100% FREE and easy to use! Merge, split, compress, convert, rotate, unlock and watermark PDFs with just a few clicks." Below this is a grid of 12 task cards, each with an icon and a title: Merge PDF, Split PDF, Compress PDF, PDF to Word, PDF to PowerPoint, PDF to Excel, Word to PDF, PowerPoint to PDF, PDF to PDF, PDF to PDF, PDF to PDF, and PDF to PDF. Each card has a brief description of the tool's function.

✓ **No pitch, no hero.** Users with specific intent land directly on the tool. Conversion happens when they hit a limit mid-task — at highest motivation.

Pattern B — Capabilities-as-Marketing Copy (Foxit, current Acrobat)

Higher friction

The screenshot shows the Foxit website. The header includes the logo and navigation links for Products, Features, Resources, Compare Foxit, Volume Licensing, Buy Now, and Log in. Below the header is a hero section with the text "The #1 Alternative to Adobe Acrobat". Below this is a grid of 2 cards. The first card is titled "The Smarter Way to Create, Edit, and Manage Documents" and describes the Foxit PDF Editor. The second card is titled "Experience fast, secure PDF editing—try it free today." and describes the Foxit PDF Editor. Below the grid is a section titled "The 2025 State of Document Intelligence" with a subtext "1,400 professionals reveal the real truth about AI, document work and productivity." and a "Get Report" button.

✗ **Features are marketing copy, not launchable tools.** A visitor who wants to merge a PDF sees "Organize PDF" in a capabilities grid — still requires a purchase to act on it.

RECOMMENDATION

Task Navigation — Adopt the Smallpdf hybrid: keep the hero, add task shortcuts below fold

✓ WHAT TO DO

→ Add a "Most Used PDF Tools" task grid below the hero fold

✗ WHAT TO AVOID

✗ Capability grids that link to feature pages, not tools

8–10 tiles, each launching directly into the tool:
Edit PDF · Sign PDF · Merge PDF · PDF to Word ·
Compress PDF · PDF to Excel · Protect PDF · OCR
PDF. Link to a full tools page below.

→ **Keep the hero section above fold — don't replace it**

Smallpdf's hybrid validates this: brand pitch above fold retains trust signals and positions quality, while task grid below captures the intent-driven visitor who already knows what they need to do.

→ **Make task tiles launchable, not navigational**

Each task tile should drop the user directly into the tool (e.g., Acrobat's online merge tool), not into a feature marketing page. iLovePDF's conversion advantage comes from zero clicks between intent and action.

"Edit PDF" that links to a capabilities overview page adds a navigation step between the visitor's intent and the action. That extra click is where competitors capture the user instead.

✗ **Removing the hero section to lead purely with tasks**

iLovePDF and PDF24 can do this because they compete on breadth and price. Acrobat competes on quality, trust, and enterprise features — the hero is where that positioning lives.

✗ **Showing fewer than 6 tasks**

Smallpdf shows 6 below fold and it works as a minimum. Showing only 2–3 creates the impression of a limited tool. iLovePDF shows 29; PDF24 shows 24. Aim for 8–10 as the right balance for Acrobat.

Evidence: iLovePDF (29 tasks above fold) and PDF24 (24 tasks, no hero) have the highest free-tier acquisition volume in the category by removing all friction between visitor intent and tool use. Smallpdf's hybrid approach — hero above fold, task grid below — is the validated middle ground for a brand like Acrobat that needs to communicate quality and trust before driving to a task. Foxit and UPDF, which show only capabilities marketing with no task grid, require a download or purchase before any action — the highest friction of the five competitors studied.

EXACT TASK TILES — IN ORDER

Section header: [Most used PDF tools](#)

Tile 1: Edit PDF → </acrobat/online/pdf-editor.html>

Tile 2: Sign PDF → </acrobat/online/sign-pdf.html>

Tile 3: Merge PDF → </acrobat/online/merge-pdf.html>

Tile 4: PDF to Word → </acrobat/online/pdf-to-word.html>

Tile 5: Compress PDF → </acrobat/online/compress-pdf.html>

Tile 6: PDF to Excel → </acrobat/online/pdf-to-excel.html>

Tile 7: Protect PDF → </acrobat/online/protect-pdf.html>

Tile 8: OCR PDF → </acrobat/online/ocr-pdf.html>

Below grid link: [See all PDF tools →](#)

SHIP DETAILS

Owner: Web team + Design

Effort: 1 sprint — new page section + direct tool link routing. Keep the hero section above fold intact.

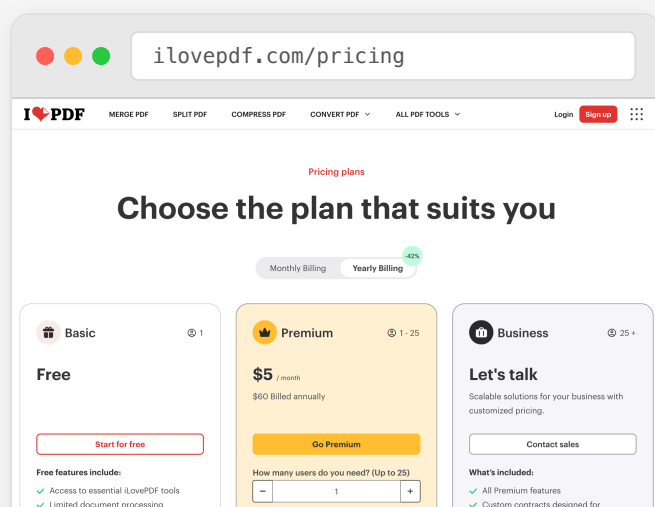
Metric to move: Hub page → direct tool session starts; time-to-tool from hub (current: requires navigation → target: 1 click from hub)

A/B test: Control (current hero-only) vs. Variant A (hero + 8-tile grid below fold) vs. Variant B (hero + 16-tile grid). Primary: direct tool session rate per hub visit. Run 3 weeks.

Critical rule: Each tile must link to the live web tool directly — not to a feature marketing page. One extra click is where competitors capture the user instead.

Pricing Page CTA Hierarchy

Should "Start free trial" or "Buy now" be the primary CTA on plans pages? Live screenshots from competitor pricing pages, April 2026.

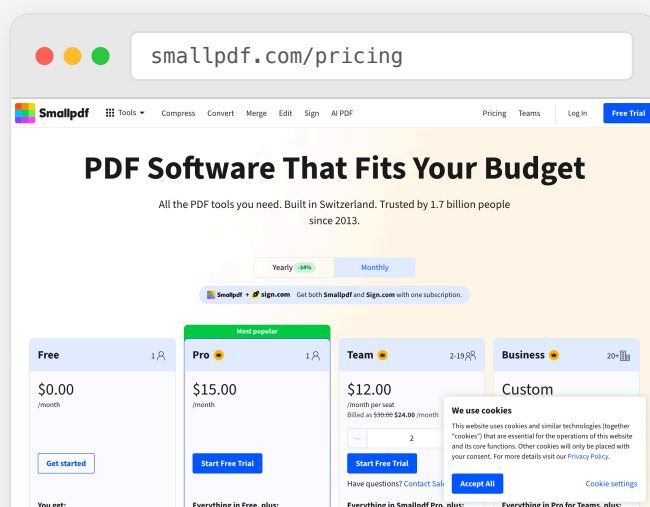


iLovePDF Pricing

Free plan first

"Start for free" is the first CTA in the plan sequence. No "Most Popular" badge — no steering toward a specific plan.

- ✓ Free plan anchors left — broadest funnel. Product quality drives upgrades, not pricing page design.

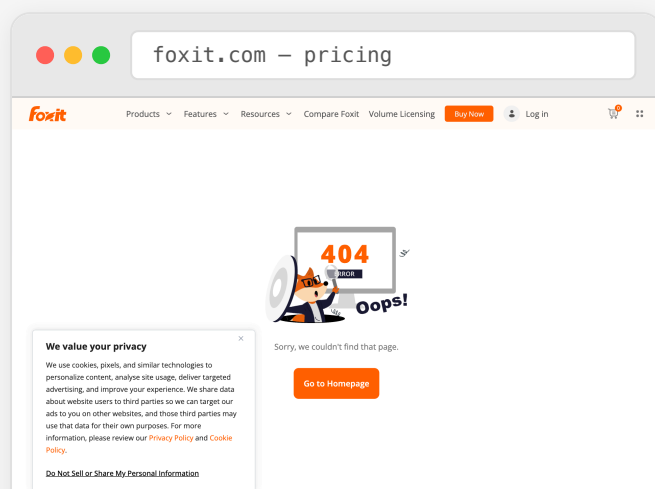


Smallpdf Pricing

Trial-first

"Try 7 Days Free" primary paid CTA. Trial framing removes commitment barrier. No "Buy Now" language anywhere.

- ✓ Trial framing defers the payment decision until after the user has experienced value — more conversion-efficient than direct purchase language.

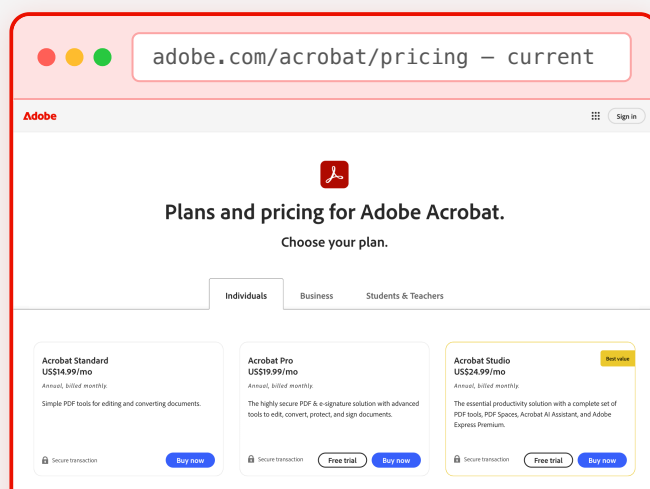


Foxit Pricing

Purchase-first

"Add to Cart" primary CTA. "Most Popular" badge on higher-priced plan. Free reader shown last.

- ⚠ "Most Popular" steers toward the higher-tier plan. Commerce-first language treats visitors as buyers before they've decided.



Adobe Acrobat Pricing — Current

Premium lead

"Get Acrobat Pro" primary. Premium plan leads the visual hierarchy. Free trial de-emphasized relative to paid entry.

- ✗ Leading with a premium plan CTA filters out the majority of visitors before they've evaluated the product. Every free-first competitor in this study leads the plan sequence with the free tier.

RECOMMENDATION

Pricing Page — Lead with free tier, demote "Buy now" to secondary on all but the top plan

✓ WHAT TO DO

→ Show the free tier first (left-most) in the plan sequence

iLovePDF does this — "Start for free" is the first CTA a visitor sees. It captures the broadest possible audience at the plans page and lets the product do the converting.

→ Make "Start free trial" the primary CTA on Acrobat Standard and mid-tier plans

Smallpdf's "Try 7 Days Free" removes the commitment barrier before a visitor has experienced value. Trial framing outperforms direct purchase language for mid-funnel visitors who are still evaluating.

→ Demote "Buy now" to an outline/secondary button on the top-tier plan only

Reserve direct purchase language for visitors who have already decided — enterprise or teams buyers who arrive at the pricing page with budget approved. All others should see trial-first language.

✗ WHAT TO AVOID

✗ "Get Acrobat Pro" as the visual anchor on the pricing page

Leading with the most expensive plan filters out the majority of visitors before they've evaluated the product at all. Zero free-first competitors do this.

✗ Placing a "Most Popular" badge on the highest-priced plan

Foxit badges their higher-tier Editor+ plan to anchor toward higher LTV. For a market leader trying to grow top-of-funnel, this signals premium-bias and discourages the self-selection that leads to long-term customer value.

✗ "Buy now" as the primary CTA across all plans

Commerce-first language on every plan treats all visitors as buyers before they've committed to a use case. It works for Foxit because Foxit explicitly targets price-sensitive switchers — not for growing a broad user base.

Evidence: iLovePDF leads with "Start for free" (free plan first). Smallpdf leads with "Try 7 Days Free" (no direct "Buy Now" anywhere on the pricing page). Both free-first competitors treat the pricing page as a funnel-widening tool, not a revenue-optimization page. Foxit's "Add to Cart" primary CTA and "Most Popular" badge on the higher-tier plan are deliberate challenger tactics designed to maximize revenue from a smaller, already-converted audience — the opposite problem from growing Acrobat's acquisition funnel.

EXACT CTA COPY PER PLAN

Plan order (left → right): Free · Standard · Pro · Teams

Free plan CTA: [Start for free](#)

Standard plan CTA: [Try 7 days free](#)

Subtext: [No credit card needed](#)

Pro plan CTA: [Try 7 days free](#) — remove "Most Popular" badge from Pro

Teams plan CTA: [Get started](#) or [Contact sales](#)

Move "Most Popular" badge: Pro → Standard (positions Standard as the conversion target, not the premium plan)

SHIP DETAILS

Owner: Web/CRO + Product

Effort: 2 days — CTA copy change + plan column reorder. No new features required.

Metric to move: Pricing page → free trial conversion rate (target: +15% vs. control)

A/B test: Control (current "Get Acrobat Pro" primary, Pro featured) vs. Variant A (free tier left, trial CTAs on all plans) vs. Variant B (Smallpdf pattern — no "Buy Now" anywhere). Primary metric: pricing page → trial start. Run 3 weeks minimum.

Secondary metric to watch: Trial → paid D30 conversion rate per variant — ensure trial-first language does not reduce paid conversion quality.

Remove from all plans: [Buy Now](#) and

[Get Acrobat Pro](#) as primary CTA language



Summary — Three Changes, Ranked by Priority

All three are CTA copy and page structure decisions. No new product features required. Highest-impact changes are in sections 1 and 3 — they can ship in the same sprint.

Priority Order for Implementation

Based on effort vs. evidence strength across all five competitor pages studied

**PRIORITY 1 · HUB
PAGE CTA · SHIP
WEEK 1**

**"Try Acrobat for free"
→ plans page as hero
CTA**

- Button copy: "Try Acrobat for free" + subtext "7 days free — no credit card"
- Add secondary outline CTA: "See all plans →"
- Apply across all customer group hubs (Acrobat, Express, Firefly)
- Owner: Web/CRO · Effort: 2 hours · Zero engineering
- A/B test: Control vs. "free" CTA vs. direct-to-tool · Metric: hero CTR

**PRIORITY 2 · PRICING
PAGE CTA · SHIP
WEEK 3**

**Free tier first, "Try 7
days free" primary on
Standard + Pro**

- Plan order: Free · Standard · Pro · Teams (left to right)
- Standard + Pro CTAs: "Try 7 days free" + "No credit card needed"
- Move "Most Popular" badge: Pro → Standard
- Remove "Buy Now" / "Get Acrobat Pro" from all non-enterprise plans
- Owner: Web/CRO + Eng · Effort: 2 days · Metric: pricing page → trial +15%

**PRIORITY 3 · TASK
NAVIGATION · SHIP
WEEK 4–5**

**Add "Most used PDF
tools" task grid below
the hero fold**

- 8 tiles: Edit · Sign · Merge · PDF→Word · Compress · PDF→Excel · Protect · OCR
- Each tile links directly to the live web tool — not a feature page
- Keep hero above fold — Smallpdf hybrid pattern
- Section header: "Most used PDF tools" + "See all →" link
- Owner: Web + Design · Effort: 1 sprint · Metric: hub → tool session rate